Our findings reveal that populists systematically withhold or distort critical scientific data, creating significant challenges for IOs. This behavior weakens IOs' ability to execute their mandates, from addressing climate change to responding to global health crises. If IOs are unable to determine the scope of these issues, it is extremely difficult to craft solutions to them. Furthermore, the erosion of domestic scientific capacity under populist regimes poses long-term risks, as it diminishes the foundation upon which IOs rely for cooperation and decision making.

3.3.3 Toxic Communication

Populist leaders can also harm IOs with toxic communication—a strategy characterized by harsh rhetoric aimed at discrediting IOs, often through speeches, party platforms, or social media. This approach sows doubt among domestic and international audiences about the legitimacy and efficacy of these institutions. In this section, we delve into a compelling case study: former US president Donald Trump's aggressive rhetoric on trade during his first term. By comparing his communication strategies with those of nonpopulist US presidents George W. Bush and Barack Obama, we illustrate how Trump leveraged rhetoric to weaken confidence in the global trade regime. The results presented here are reproduced from Carnegie and Carson (2019), which provides further details.

Trade occupies a particularly salient and contentious space in global governance, overseen by the WTO and a web of preferential trade agreements (e.g., USMCA, EU-MERCOSUR). Despite a decline in actual trade violations during Trump's presidency, his rhetoric consistently alleged widespread noncompliance, creating the impression of a fundamentally broken system.

Trump's rhetoric frequently accused other nations of violating trade rules. For example, he declared, "We are going to end the international abuse, the foreign cheating, and the one-sided rules that govern NAFTA and the WTO."[10] Trump amplified his trade rhetoric through Twitter (now X), posting more than 130 tweets accusing countries of unfair trade practices during this time. For example: "We cannot keep a blind eye to the rampant unfair trade practices against our Country!" (March 14, 2018) and "After many decades, fair and reciprocal Trade will happen!" (June 9, 2018). By